

It is now quite well-known that the two behemoths among free software operating systems, the ones that both represent and impact GNU/Linux, are Red Hat's Fedora and Ubuntu from Canonical. Ubuntu's latest version, 11.04, also known as the Natty Narwhal, was released on 28th April, and a review of this version appeared in the June edition of *Linux For You*. Fedora followed on 24th May with version 15, codenamed Lovelock. Now, when you have two such similar releases at practically the same time, it creates rather a 'Big Choice', and it might even create a 'Big Dilemma'. So, how do the two stack up against each other?

Delving into the core

Examining the core first, we find that the foundations of both are almost the same. The kernel is at version 2.6.38 in Natty, with Lovelock's just a few point releases ahead. Kernel version 2.6.38 brings a lot of desktop-oriented improvements, resulting in much better desktop performance than was previously the norm. Both distributions have the *xorg-server* at 1.10.1, *udev* version 167 and *freetype* version 2.4.4. However, while Ubuntu has already been using GRUB 2 at version 1.99rc1, Fedora staunchly continues with GRUB 1 at version 0.97. Whichever version you use, this aspect does not create much of a hassle—just the method of configuring GRUB differs in the two versions. Another area of difference is GCC. Lovelock includes version 4.6.0 of the compiler



Figure 1: GNOME 3 desktop



Figure 2: GNOME 3 calendar

collection, while Natty includes 4.5.2—so developers who want that wee bit more, may be happier with Lovelock.

With the preliminaries over, let's get around to the more visible aspects and look at the giants from the outside!

The desktop environments

We will not compare KDE on the two distros. The first reason is that, both of them include version 4.6.2 of KDE; second, KDE is not the default environment of either distribution; and third, KDE 4.6 is not as radically different from 4.5 as the default environments of Lovelock and Natty are from their previous counterparts.

Lovelock and GNOME 3

Lovelock is the first major distribution to include GNOME 3 as the default desktop environment (see Figure 1) and GNOME 3 is... well, there's a lot to say about GNOME 3. Even if you are not biased, you have to admit that GNOME 3 makes almost everything harder than it was previously. A major issue with software developers is their desire to reinvent everything from scratch. This is not essentially a bad thing, and GNOME up to its major version 2, GNOME was definitely plagued by legacy code such as CORBA.



Figure 3: GNOME 3 network menu

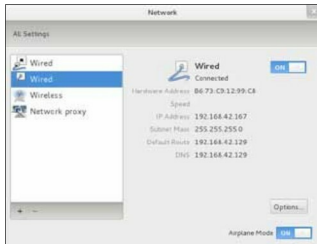


Figure 4: GNOME 3 network settings